NEW JERSEY

The Garden State



In the winter of 1856, a Newark-born businessman named John Taylor walked the bustling market streets of Trenton, New Jersey, watching Irish and German immigrant laborers pour off the docks and into the factories and rail yards that were turning the state into an industrial powerhouse. These were men who worked long hours with their hands and needed food that was cheap, filling, and ready fast. Taylor saw the gap and filled it with a recipe that would outlast everything else he ever did.

Taylor's creation was a cured, spiced pork product rolled tightly in a cloth casing—practical, affordable, and packed with a salty, savory flavor that was unlike anything else on the market. He called it Taylor's Prepared Ham, and he sold it through his company out of Trenton, packaging it in a way that kept it fresh without refrigeration at a time when iceboxes were a luxury most working families couldn't afford. The laborers who built New Jersey's railroads, staffed its textile mills, and worked its ironworks embraced it immediately. It was protein, it was fast, and it tasted good—three things that mattered deeply when you had twelve hours of work ahead of you.

By the early 1900s, Taylor's product had become a fixture in New Jersey's corner stores, butcher shops, and home kitchens from Camden to Hoboken. Sliced thick on a griddle until the edges curled and crisped into caramelized rings, tucked into a hard Kaiser roll with a fried egg and a slice of American cheese—this was the breakfast that fueled the state. Diners from Newark to the Jersey Shore put it on their menus and never took it off. It became the kind of food that people didn't think of as regional until they left home and couldn't find it anywhere else.

The name itself became its own small cultural battleground. In South Jersey and Philadelphia, people called it pork roll. In North Jersey, Taylor Ham. The debate—fierce, affectionate, and entirely unresolved—became as much a part of New Jersey identity as the Turnpike or the boardwalk. Ask someone where they're from in New Jersey and then ask them what they call it. You'll have your answer in seconds.

What Taylor stumbled onto in Trenton was something deeper than a cured meat product. He had created a food that crossed lines—ethnic, economic, and geographic—at a time when those lines were drawn hard. Irish immigrants, German butchers, Italian deli owners, and eventually diners of every background all claimed it as their own, because in a very real sense, it was. Pork roll belongs to New Jersey the way gumbo belongs to Louisiana or cheesesteaks belong to Philadelphia—forged from a specific place, a specific hunger, and the specific people who showed up there.

When you slice into a roll of pork roll and lay those rounds on a hot cast iron pan, you are going to hear exactly what New Jersey mornings have sounded like for over 150 years—that sizzle, that curl, that smell. Cut the slits in the edges so they lie flat, let them go until the surface deepens to a rich, crackling brown, and get your egg ready. This is one of those rare dishes that tastes precisely like where it comes from, and once you make it, you'll understand completely why an entire state has never stopped arguing about what to call it.

PORK ROLL

Pork roll—that salty, griddle-crisped New Jersey treasure—is the kind of simple pleasure that turns an ordinary breakfast into a small, perfect moment you didn't know you needed.

Yield: 2 sandwiches

INGREDIENTS

- 4 slices pork roll (Taylor Ham or similar brand)
- 2 large eggs
- 2 slices American cheese
- 2 sturdy Kaiser or hard rolls (or English muffins)
- Butter or oil, for frying
- Salt and pepper, to taste
- Ketchup, hot sauce, or salt-pepper-ketchup combo (optional, the Jersey way)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Prep the pork roll*: Use a small knife to make four shallow slits around the edges of each pork roll slice—this prevents curling while frying.
2. *Fry the pork roll*: Heat a skillet over medium heat. Add the pork roll slices and cook until browned and slightly crisp on both sides, 2–3 minutes per side. Remove and set aside.
3. *Cook the eggs*: In the same skillet, crack the eggs and cook to your liking-over easy, medium, or hard. Season lightly with salt and pepper.
4. *Melt the cheese*: Place a slice of American cheese on each egg and cover briefly to melt.
5. *Assemble the sandwich*: Split the rolls and lightly toast them if desired. Layer two slices of pork roll on the bottom half, top with the cheesy egg, and finish with your preferred condiments.
6. *Serve hot*: Wrap in deli paper or foil for that authentic Jersey diner feel and enjoy immediately.

